

IELTS Band 7 Preparation Plan

A focused 30–45 day study plan for working professionals

For: a 25-year-old IT professional in India

Target: **Band 7** (Academic) for Master's admission abroad

Daily commitment: 2–3 hours weekdays · 5–6 hours weekends

Edition: 2026

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1. IELTS — What It Is & What Band 7 Means

1.1 Test format at a glance

Section	Duration	Format	Questions
Listening	30 min + 10 min transfer	4 recordings (everyday + academic)	40
Reading (Academic)	60 min	3 long academic passages	40
Writing (Academic)	60 min	Task 1 (150 w) + Task 2 (250 w)	2
Speaking	11–14 min	Face-to-face / video interview	3 parts

Listening & Speaking are **identical** for Academic and General Training. Only Reading and Writing differ. You will sit the **Academic** version for a Master's.

1.2 Band 7 — what it actually requires

Section	Raw / criteria for Band 7
Listening	30–32 correct out of 40
Reading (Academic)	30–32 correct out of 40
Writing	Score of 7 on each of: Task Response · Coherence & Cohesion · Lexical Resource · Grammatical Range & Accuracy
Speaking	Score of 7 on each of: Fluency & Coherence · Lexical Resource · Grammatical Range & Accuracy · Pronunciation

Reality check for Indian candidates: Listening and Reading are usually the easiest to score Band 7+ on (test-taking technique). **Writing and Speaking are the bottlenecks** — most Band 6.5 candidates are losing points there. Budget 60% of your study time on Writing + Speaking.

1.3 Band targets typical universities ask for

Country	Typical overall	No band less than
UK (most Master's)	6.5 – 7.0	6.0 – 6.5
Canada	6.5 – 7.0	6.0
Australia / NZ	6.5 – 7.0	6.0

USA	6.5 – 7.5 (TOEFL more common)	6.5
Germany / Netherlands / Ireland	6.5	6.0
Top-tier (Oxbridge, Imperial, etc.)	7.0 – 7.5	6.5 – 7.0

Targeting **Band 7 overall with 6.5 in every band** opens almost every Master's programme in the English-speaking world.

2. Diagnostic Test (Day 0) & Weak-Area Mapping

Before any study, take one full official mock test under exam conditions. This single step saves weeks of misdirected effort.

2.1 How to take the diagnostic

1. Use a recent **Cambridge IELTS book (16, 17, 18 or 19)** — Test 1.
2. One sitting on a Sunday morning. No breaks except between sections.
3. Listening & Reading: use the official answer key.
4. Writing: don't self-score — keep it for an evaluator (see §13).
5. Speaking: record yourself answering Part 1, Part 2, Part 3 questions from any official source. Listen back.

2.2 Map your weaknesses

If your diagnostic shows...	Likely root cause	Where to invest first
Listening < 28	Not reading questions ahead; spelling errors	Section §5, daily 1 test
Reading < 28	Reading every word; mis-handling T/F/NG	Section §6, skim-scan drills
Writing weak T1	No overview; over-detail	Section §7, template
Writing weak T2	Off-topic; weak structure; repetitive vocab	Section §8, essay types + collocations
Speaking — hesitation	Searching for words; over-thinking grammar	Section §9, daily 30-min practice
Speaking — accent / clarity	Indian-English habits, fast speech	Section §12, slow down + record

3. The 45-Day Plan (With 30-Day Accelerator)

Six weeks total. If you only have 30 days, compress Weeks 1+2 into 5 days and Weeks 5+6 into 7 days — the structure remains the same.

3.1 Phase overview

Phase	Days	Focus	Outcome
Foundation	1–7	Diagnostic, familiarise format, build routine	You know the test inside out
Listening + Reading	8–14	Daily timed sections; question-type drills	L & R consistently $\geq 30/40$
Writing	15–24	1 essay/day, evaluator feedback weekly	Repeatable Band-7 templates
Speaking	25–32	Cue cards, recording, speaking partner	2-min fluent answers
Integrated mocks	33–40	Full timed tests, mistake-log review	Stamina + consistency
Polish + Rest	41–45	Light review, sleep, test-day strategy	Calm, confident, peak

3.2 Week 1 (Days 1–7) — Foundation

Day 1 — Full diagnostic mock (3 hr morning + 30 min speaking afternoon).

Day 2 — Score it. Read the official band descriptors for all four sections.

Day 3 — Study the format of all 4 sections + question types (this PDF, §5–9).

Day 4 — Listening: 1 test, slow speed if needed, learn 5 question types.

Day 5 — Reading: 1 passage, learn T/F/NG vs Yes/No/NG.

Day 6 — Writing T1: read 5 model answers, note structure.

Day 7 — Speaking: read Part 1/2/3 sample questions; record one answer.

3.3 Week 2 (Days 8–14) — Listening + Reading core

Weekdays: 45 min Listening + 60 min Reading per day. Always review wrong answers.

Weekend: 1 full Listening test + 1 full Reading test (timed). Log all mistakes by category.

Use the same Cambridge book throughout. Don't bounce between resources.

3.4 Week 3 (Days 15–21) — Writing core part 1

Days 15–17 (T1): Write 1 Task 1 daily — bar / line / pie / table / process / map (one of each).

Days 18–21 (T2): Write 1 Task 2 daily — opinion, discussion, problem/solution, two-part question.

Sunday: Get 2 essays evaluated by an examiner (paid online service).

3.5 Week 4 (Days 22–28) — Writing finish + Speaking start

Mon–Wed: Continue Writing — re-do essays from Week 3 with evaluator feedback. Lock your template.

Thu–Sun: Speaking — 4 Part-1 topics + 1 Part-2 cue card + 4 Part-3 questions per day. **Record every session.**

3.6 Week 5 (Days 29–35) — Speaking + first integrated mocks

Speaking daily: 30 min cue-card + Part-3 with a speaking partner (italki / Cambly / a friend abroad).

Sunday: Full mock test (all 4 sections, timed, paper-based even if your real test is computer-based).

3.7 Week 6 (Days 36–45) — Mocks & polish

Days 36–42: 3 full mocks. After each, spend 90 min reviewing mistakes.

Days 43–45: Light review only — no new material. Sleep 8 hours. Re-read your templates and Indian-English pitfalls list.

3.8 30-day accelerator

Week	What changes
1 (Days 1–5)	Diagnostic Day 1; format + L & R techniques Days 2–5
2 (Days 6–12)	Heavy Writing (1 essay/day) + Reading (1 passage/day)
3 (Days 13–19)	Speaking-heavy + Listening (1 test/day)
4 (Days 20–26)	Daily full mocks alternated with skill repair
Final 4 (Days 27–30)	Light review, 1 final mock, mental prep

4. Your Daily Routine as a Working Professional

4.1 Weekday — 2.5 hours total (split)

Slot	Duration	What to do
Morning (6:30–7:15 AM)	45 min	Listening test OR Reading passage (timed)
Lunch break	20 min	Vocabulary flashcards (Quizlet / AWL list) — 30 words/day
Commute	30 min	IELTS podcast or BBC 6-Minute English (listening exposure)
Evening (8:30–9:30 PM)	60 min	Phase-specific: Writing essay OR Speaking practice

4.2 Weekend — 5–6 hours total (one block per day)

Day	Block
Saturday morning (3 hr)	Mistake-log review + 1 skill-specific deep dive
Saturday evening (1 hr)	Speaking with partner (Cambly / friend)
Sunday morning (3 hr)	Full mock or 2 timed mini-mocks (alternating weeks)

Non-negotiables: 7+ hours sleep · timed practice from Day 1 · a notebook (paper or digital) for your *mistake log*. The single highest-leverage habit is reviewing the mistake log every Sunday.

5. Listening — Strategy, Question Types, Traps

5.1 Structure

Part	Context	Voices	Difficulty
1	Everyday (e.g., booking a hotel, joining a gym)	2 people	Easy
2	Everyday monologue (tour guide, instructions)	1 person	Medium
3	Academic discussion (tutor + 1–2 students)	2–4 people	Medium-hard
4	Academic lecture / talk	1 person	Hardest

5.2 Question types you must master

- **Form / note / table / flow-chart completion** — usually Part 1, 2. Watch word limit (max 2/3 words).
- **Multiple choice** — listen for paraphrase; the wrong options are usually mentioned to distract.
- **Matching** — items to options. Mark guesses, come back.
- **Plan / map / diagram labelling** — Part 2 favourite. Use directions (north, opposite, next to).
- **Sentence completion** — exact wording from audio.
- **Short answer** — usually 1–3 words; spelling counts.

5.3 The 7 listening rules

1. **Read questions during the audio gaps.** You get ~30 sec before each section.
2. **Predict the answer type** — number, place, name, date.
3. **Watch for distractors** — speakers correct themselves: "It's on Tuesday — sorry, Wednesday." The answer is Wednesday.
4. **Plurals and articles matter.** "book" ≠ "books".
5. **Spelling matters.** Common traps: *accommodation, necessary, foreign*.
6. **Don't get stuck.** If you miss one, move on — you'll lose three more.
7. **Use the 10 minutes** at the end to transfer answers carefully (paper test).

Number traps: "30" and "13" sound similar; "fifty" and "fifteen". Listen for the stress — FIFteen vs fifTY.

5.4 Daily listening drill

1. One full timed test (30 min + 10 min transfer).

2. Mark answers from the key.
3. For every wrong answer: listen to that segment again with the transcript, underline the exact phrase that gave the answer.
4. Note the question type in your mistake log.

6. Reading — Strategy, Question Types, Time Budget

6.1 Structure (Academic)

- 3 passages, ~700–900 words each, drawn from journals, books, magazines.
- 40 questions total. Difficulty rises from Passage 1 to Passage 3.
- No extra transfer time — write answers on the answer sheet as you go.

6.2 Time budget

Step	Time
Passage 1	17 min
Passage 2	20 min
Passage 3	22 min
Buffer / re-check	1 min

6.3 Question types (and how to attack each)

Type	Strategy
True / False / Not Given (facts)	Find the exact statement in the passage. <i>True</i> = says the same thing (paraphrased). <i>False</i> = passage contradicts it. <i>Not Given</i> = passage doesn't mention it (don't infer).
Yes / No / Not Given (opinions)	Same logic but applies to the writer's <i>opinions</i> , not facts.
Matching headings	Do last. Read paragraph topic sentence + last sentence. Match to heading.
Matching information	Find specific information. Use keywords like <i>example</i> , <i>reason</i> , <i>definition</i> .
Matching features (people / dates)	Scan for proper nouns first; match the surrounding claim.
Multiple choice	Eliminate two clearly wrong; pick the closer remaining.
Sentence / summary completion	Identify the keyword in the sentence; locate in passage; word limit matters.

Short answer	Word limit applies; exact wording from passage.
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6.4 The skim–scan–solve method

1. **Skim** the passage (90 seconds): read title, first paragraph, first sentence of each paragraph, last paragraph. Get the gist.
2. **Scan** for keywords as you answer each question. **Don't re-read.**
3. **Solve** — questions usually follow the passage's order (except matching headings).

Band-7 difference: people who score Band 7 don't read faster — they decide faster when to skip. If a question takes > 90 seconds, guess and move on.

7. Writing Task 1 — Graphs, Charts, Processes, Maps

20 min. 150 words minimum (write ~170). No personal opinion. Just describe what you see.

7.1 Task 1 sub-types

- Bar chart · Line graph · Pie chart · Table
- Process diagram (flow with stages)
- Map / plan (with comparison over time)

7.2 Universal Task 1 structure

1. **Introduction** (1 sentence) — paraphrase the question.
2. **Overview** (2 sentences, **essential for Band 7**) — 2–3 key trends. **No specific data.**
3. **Body 1** (2–3 sentences) — most striking detail, with data.
4. **Body 2** (2–3 sentences) — the rest, with data.

7.3 Template — line/bar/table (over time)

The [chart / graph / table] illustrates [topic] [in / from] [place / time period].

Overall, it is clear that [main trend 1], while [main trend 2 – contrast or stability].

To begin with, in [year], [item A] stood at [value], the [highest / lowest] of all categories. This figure then [rose / fell] [steadily / sharply] to [value] by [year]. Meanwhile, [item B] showed [opposite / similar] movement.

In addition, [items C and D] remained relatively stable across the period, fluctuating between [value] and [value]. By the end of the period, [summary comparison].

7.4 Template — process diagram

The diagram depicts the process of [topic], which can be divided into [N] main stages.

Overall, the process begins with [start point] and concludes with [end point]; it is a [natural / man-made] [linear / cyclical] process.

To begin with, [stage 1 description]. Following this, [stage 2].
Subsequently, [stage 3] takes place, during which [detail].
Finally, [last stage]. Once complete, [end-state description].

7.5 Template — map / plan

The two maps illustrate the [town / building / area] of [name] [before and after / in YYYY and YYYY].

Overall, the area has undergone considerable change, with [main change 1] and [main change 2] being the most notable.

To begin with, in [earlier year], [original feature] was located in [direction]. By [later year], this had been [replaced by / demolished / converted into] [new feature].

Furthermore, [second change with location detail].
[Closing comparison sentence].

7.6 High-value vocabulary for Task 1

Trend	Words to use
Increase	rose, climbed, surged, soared, grew, picked up
Decrease	fell, declined, dropped, plummeted, dipped, decreased
Stay the same	remained stable, levelled off, held steady, plateaued
Fluctuate	fluctuated, varied, oscillated
Reach peak	peaked at, reached a high of, hit a maximum of
Reach bottom	bottomed out at, hit a low of
Degree	slightly, gradually, steadily, sharply, dramatically, significantly

Common Task 1 mistakes: missing the overview, listing every data point, copying the question verbatim, adding opinions ("This is good for the economy" — never).

8. Writing Task 2 — Essay Types & Templates

40 min. 250 words minimum (write ~280–300). This is the section where most Band 7 candidates win or lose.

8.1 The four essay types

Type	Typical phrasing	Structure
Opinion (Agree/Disagree)	"To what extent do you agree..."	Intro (thesis) → 2 supporting body paragraphs → Conclusion
Discussion (Both views)	"Discuss both views and give your own opinion"	Intro → View 1 → View 2 → My view → Conclusion (or merge view + opinion)
Problem & Solution	"What are the problems? What can be done?"	Intro → Problems → Solutions → Conclusion
Two-part question	"Why has this happened? What can governments do?"	Intro → Answer part 1 → Answer part 2 → Conclusion

8.2 Universal structure (4 paragraphs)

1. **Introduction** (40–50 words) — paraphrase the topic, state your position / preview.
2. **Body 1** (90–100 words) — topic sentence + explain + example + link.
3. **Body 2** (90–100 words) — same structure with a different idea.
4. **Conclusion** (40–50 words) — restate position + summarise.

8.3 Opinion essay template

It is widely argued that [paraphrase of topic]. While some maintain that [opposing view], I firmly believe that [your position] for the following reasons.

To begin with, [first reason]. [Explain in 1–2 sentences why this matters.] For instance, [a concrete, plausible example – country, study, daily life]. This clearly demonstrates that [link back to position].

Furthermore, [second reason], which arguably outweighs counter-arguments. [Explain.] A case in point is [example]. Consequently, [link back].

In conclusion, although [brief nod to the other side], the evidence strongly suggests that [restate position]. [One forward-looking sentence about implications.]

8.4 Discussion essay template

The question of [topic] has provoked considerable debate. While some argue that [view A], others contend that [view B]. In my opinion, [your stance].

On the one hand, supporters of [view A] point out that [reason]. For example, [evidence/example]. From their perspective, [implication].

On the other hand, opponents argue that [reason for view B]. [Example.] They maintain that [implication].

Personally, I side with the latter view because [your main reason + short example]. While [view A] has some merit, the broader benefits of [view B] make it the more compelling position.

8.5 Problem-Solution template

In recent years, [paraphrase the issue] has become a pressing concern. This essay will examine the main causes and propose practical solutions.

The principal problem lies in [problem 1], which leads to [consequence]. For example, [evidence]. A further issue is [problem 2]; [brief explanation].

To address these challenges, governments could [solution 1] – for instance, [concrete example]. Equally important, [solution 2 at individual / community level] would [outcome].

In conclusion, [restate the issue] requires action from both authorities and individuals. With [solution 1] and [solution 2], the situation can be significantly improved.

8.6 Cohesive devices to use sparingly but precisely

Function	Words / phrases
Adding	Furthermore · Moreover · In addition · Additionally
Contrast	However · Nevertheless · On the other hand · Conversely
Cause	Owing to · As a result of · Because of · Due to
Effect	Therefore · Consequently · As a result · Hence
Example	For instance · A case in point is · To illustrate
Concession	Although · Despite · While it is true that

Conclusion	In conclusion · To sum up · Overall
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8.7 Topics to prepare ideas for

- **Education** — online vs traditional; arts vs STEM; standardised testing.
- **Environment** — climate change; recycling; renewable energy; individual vs government responsibility.
- **Technology** — social media; AI; remote work; smartphones & children.
- **Health** — obesity; fast food; preventive vs curative; mental health.
- **Work** — work-life balance; gig economy; retirement age; women in the workforce.
- **Society** — ageing population; immigration; crime & punishment; tourism's impact.
- **Government** — taxation; arts funding; public transport; censorship.

Build an idea bank. For each of the 7 topics above, write 2 pros, 2 cons, 1 example. 14 pros + 14 cons + 7 examples = the raw material for almost any Task 2 essay.

Band-7 killers in Writing: not addressing every part of the question; vague positions ("there are both pros and cons"); memorised answers (examiners spot them); repeating the same word 5 times; using "etc." or contractions.

9. Speaking — Part 1, 2, 3 with Cue-Card Bank

9.1 Structure

Part	Duration	What happens
1	4–5 min	Examiner asks general questions about you (home, work, hobbies, food, etc.)
2	3–4 min (1 min prep, 2 min talk)	You receive a cue card and speak for ~2 min
3	4–5 min	Abstract follow-up discussion related to your Part-2 topic

9.2 The four criteria (each marked separately)

Criterion	Band 7 means...
Fluency & Coherence	You speak at length without much hesitation; ideas are linked logically.
Lexical Resource	Wide vocabulary, some less common words, ability to paraphrase, occasional inaccuracies.
Grammatical Range & Accuracy	Mix of simple and complex sentences, most error-free.
Pronunciation	Clear, easy to understand throughout, individual sounds and word stress mostly correct.

9.3 Part 1 — common topic clusters

The examiner picks 3–4 of these clusters. Prepare 4–5 sentences per cluster with at least one less-common word or idiomatic phrase.

- Hometown · Where you live now · Studies · Work
- Hobbies · Sports · Music · Books · Movies
- Food · Cooking · Restaurants
- Family · Friends · Neighbours
- Travel · Holidays · Weather · Seasons
- Technology · Phones · Social media
- Daily routine · Mornings · Sleep
- Shopping · Clothes · Money

Example: Q: *Do you enjoy cooking?*

A: "Honestly, I'd say I have a love-hate relationship with cooking. On weekends I genuinely enjoy

experimenting with recipes — I've recently been trying Thai cuisine, which is surprisingly approachable once you get the basic curry pastes right. On weekdays though, I tend to fall back on quick stir-fries because I'm usually exhausted after work."

9.4 Part 2 — the cue card

You'll get a card like:

Describe a person who has influenced you.

You should say:

- who this person is
- how you know them
- what they have done
- and explain why they have influenced you.

Cue-card answer structure (use the WWHE method)

1. **Who / What** — name and one-line description (15 sec)
2. **When / Where / How** — context (30 sec)
3. **What happened / What they did** — the specifics (45 sec)
4. **Explanation / Reflection** — why it matters to you (30 sec)

Useful opening phrases

- "I'd like to talk about..."
- "The first thing that comes to mind is..."
- "There are several I could choose from, but the one that stands out is..."

9.5 Cue-card bank — prepare 1 personal story per card

1. A person who influenced you
2. A book / film that affected you
3. A place you'd like to visit
4. A skill you want to learn
5. A memorable journey
6. A time you helped someone
7. A time you were nervous
8. A piece of technology you can't live without
9. A decision you made recently
10. An item of clothing you like
11. A historical event you find interesting
12. A teacher you remember
13. A meal you enjoyed
14. A goal you've achieved
15. A creative person you know

Have **two flexible stories** — say, a memorable trip and an influential mentor — that you can adapt to most cue cards. Saves prep time and reduces anxiety.

9.6 Part 3 — discussion

The examiner asks abstract follow-ups. Band 7 demands you go beyond a 1-sentence answer.

The PEEL framework for each Part-3 answer

- **Point** — direct answer
- **Explain** — why
- **Example** — concrete instance
- **Link** — broader implication or a "however"

Example: Q: *Do you think it's important for children to learn from their grandparents?*

A: "Definitely — I'd say it's invaluable. Grandparents carry decades of perspective that parents, who are usually preoccupied with day-to-day demands, can't always offer. In my own family, my grandfather taught me the value of patience through gardening — something I doubt I'd have picked up otherwise. That said, the relationship has to be balanced; grandparents shouldn't become the sole authority because children still need their parents' direct involvement."

9.7 Speaking practice — daily 30 minutes

1. Pick 2 Part-1 topics → speak 30 seconds each → record.
2. Pick 1 cue card → 1 min prep → 2 min talk → record.
3. Pick 3 Part-3 questions → answer each in PEEL format.
4. Listen to the recording. Count: filler words, repeated vocab, grammar slips. Re-do the worst one.

10. Vocabulary & Collocations for Band 7

10.1 The three pillars

- **Range** — using less-common words appropriately.
- **Collocations** — words that naturally go together (*strong tea*, NOT *powerful tea*).
- **Paraphrasing** — saying the same thing in different words.

10.2 Daily vocab routine

1. 30 new Academic-Word-List words per day (Quizlet deck).
2. For each word, learn: meaning · 1 collocation · 1 example sentence.
3. Use 5 of the day's new words in a Speaking practice that evening.

10.3 Synonyms you should know cold

Common	Band-7 alternatives
important	crucial, vital, significant, paramount, pivotal
good	beneficial, advantageous, valuable, worthwhile
bad	detrimental, harmful, adverse, unfavourable
big	substantial, considerable, significant, sizeable
show	demonstrate, illustrate, indicate, reveal
think	believe, maintain, argue, contend, assert
cause (verb)	lead to, result in, give rise to, trigger
increase	rise, climb, surge, soar, grow
decrease	fall, decline, drop, plummet, dwindle
problem	issue, challenge, obstacle, drawback
solution	remedy, measure, approach, intervention
people	individuals, citizens, the public, the population

10.4 High-impact collocations

- play a [crucial / pivotal / vital] role in...
- have a [profound / significant / lasting] impact on...

- raise [awareness of / concerns about]...
- address an issue · tackle a problem · combat poverty
- strike a balance between... and...
- shed light on... · come to terms with... · pave the way for...
- a heated debate · a widely-held belief · a common misconception

10.5 Idioms — use 1–2 in Speaking, almost never in Writing

- *On the same page* — in agreement
- *Hit the ground running* — start strongly
- *Out of the blue* — unexpectedly
- *A double-edged sword* — has both pros and cons
- *Get the hang of it* — learn how to do it

Don't force idioms into Writing — they're informal. Examiners penalise inappropriate register.

11. Grammar Essentials & Indian-English Pitfalls

11.1 The five grammar areas that decide Band 7

1. **Tenses** — past simple vs present perfect; future forms.
2. **Articles** (a / an / the) — Indian speakers omit or overuse.
3. **Subject-verb agreement** — especially with collective nouns.
4. **Conditionals** — zero, first, second, third, mixed.
5. **Relative clauses** — who / whom / which / that / whose.

11.2 Articles — quick rules

Use	Example
a / an — first mention, singular countable	I saw a film yesterday.
the — second mention, or unique	The film was about climate change.
no article — general plurals or uncountables	Children need education .
the — unique entities	the internet, the sun, the environment, the government

11.3 Indian-English habits to stop in the test

Avoid	Use instead
"I am having a doubt."	"I have a doubt." (state verbs don't use continuous)
"Discuss about this."	"Discuss this." ("discuss" needs no preposition)
"He is good in maths."	"He is good at maths."
"Cope up with stress."	"Cope with stress." (no "up")
"What is your good name?"	"What is your name?"
"I will revert back."	"I will reply / respond." (revert = return to a prior state)
"Out of station"	"Out of town" / "away"
"Prepone the meeting."	"Bring the meeting forward."

"He is doing the needful."	"He is taking care of it."
"Only" / "itself" added everywhere	Drop them — "I came yesterday <i>only</i> " → "I came yesterday."
"Lakhs / crores"	"Hundreds of thousands / millions"
"Passing out from college"	"Graduating from college"
"Pass percentage"	"Pass rate"

11.4 Sentence variety for Band 7

Don't write or speak only in simple sentences. Mix the four sentence types:

- **Simple:** Children need exercise.
- **Compound:** Children need exercise, and they need a balanced diet.
- **Complex:** Although children need exercise, many of them spend hours on screens.
- **Compound-complex:** Although children need exercise, many spend hours on screens, and parents struggle to set limits.

11.5 Conditionals at a glance

Type	Form	Example
Zero (general truth)	If + present, present	If you heat water, it boils.
First (real future)	If + present, will + V	If I study hard, I will score 7.
Second (unreal present)	If + past, would + V	If I were richer, I would travel more.
Third (unreal past)	If + past perfect, would have + V3	If I had started earlier, I would have finished.
Mixed	Combination	If I had taken IELTS last year, I would already be in the UK.

12. Pronunciation for Indian Speakers

12.1 The five things Band-7 examiners listen for

1. **Individual sounds** — V/W, TH, S/SH, P/B clearly distinct.
2. **Word stress** — PHOto vs phoTOgraphy.
3. **Sentence stress** — content words louder than function words.
4. **Linking** — "would you" → "wud-ja", "want it" → "wan-it".
5. **Intonation** — rise for questions, fall for statements.

12.2 Indian-speaker sound traps

Sound pair	Issue	Practice words
V vs W	Often merged	vine / wine · vest / west · vow / wow
TH (voiced)	Sounds like D	this · these · those · though · brother
TH (unvoiced)	Sounds like T	think · three · through · cloth · path
P / F	Sometimes merged	park / fork · pin / fin
S / SH	Confused	sip / ship · sin / shin · seat / sheet
Long vs short vowels	Short ones rushed	ship / sheep · live / leave · bit / beat
Final consonants	Dropped	night t , help p , list t , last t

12.3 Word stress shifts

Word family	Stress moves
PHOto <u>graph</u> · phoTO <u>grapher</u> · photo <u>GRAPHic</u>	shifts by suffix
ECON <u>omy</u> · ecoNO <u>mical</u> · ecoNO <u>mics</u> · ecoNO <u>mist</u>	same root
POL <u>itics</u> · poL <u>itical</u> · politi <u>Clan</u>	watch suffix
NOUN: a RE <u>Cord</u> · VERB: to re <u>CORD</u>	noun-verb pairs

12.4 Two habits that boost your pronunciation overnight

1. **Slow down by 20%.** Indians often speak fast; clarity wins over speed.
2. **Pause at commas and full stops.** Use pauses instead of "umm".

12.5 Shadowing — the single best pronunciation drill

1. Find a 2-minute English podcast clip (BBC, TED-Ed).
2. Listen once for sense.
3. Play in 10-second chunks; repeat each chunk aloud, matching rhythm and intonation.
4. Record yourself reading the transcript and compare to the original.
5. 10 minutes a day for 3 weeks visibly improves your prosody.

13. Mock Tests & Self-Evaluation

13.1 The mock schedule

Week	Mocks
1	1 diagnostic (full)
2	1 timed Listening + 1 timed Reading separately
3	2 timed Writing tasks evaluated
4	2 Speaking mocks (recorded or with partner)
5	1 full mock (Sunday)
6	3 full mocks (one every other day) + 1 final mock 4 days before the real test

13.2 How to self-score Listening & Reading

1. Use the official Cambridge answer key — exact spelling.
2. Convert raw score to band using the official table (varies by test).

13.3 How to get Writing evaluated

- Paid online evaluation: IELTS Liz Writing Correction, IELTSAdvantage, IELTS Online Tests (~ ₹500–800 per essay).
- British Council and IDP Premium Materials include written feedback.
- If budget-constrained: use ChatGPT/Claude with a "you are an IELTS examiner" prompt as a first pass, but pay for at least **2 real-examiner evaluations** before the test.

13.4 How to get Speaking evaluated

- Cambly / italki tutors marked as "IELTS speaking examiner" (~ ₹600–1200 per 30 min).
- Reddit r/IELTS — exchange recordings with another candidate.
- Record + self-evaluate using the band descriptors (good but ceiling).

13.5 The mistake log — your highest-leverage document

One notebook. Four columns:

Date	Section	Question type / mistake	Lesson learned
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11-Jul	Listening Part 3	Lost track during MCQ — distractor "Tuesday"	Read all options before audio starts
11-Jul	Reading Passage 3	Marked T instead of NG	If passage doesn't say it explicitly, it's NG — don't infer

Review every Sunday before your weekly mock. Most of your improvement comes from this single habit.

14. Resources — Free & Paid

14.1 Books

- **Cambridge IELTS 14–19** — the only official practice tests. Use 16, 17, 18, 19 in this order.
- **The Official Cambridge Guide to IELTS** — explanations + tests.
- **IELTS Trainer 2 Academic** — graded difficulty.
- **Collins Vocabulary for IELTS** · **Collins Grammar for IELTS**.

14.2 Free websites

- **IELTS Liz** (ieltsliz.com) — strongest free Writing & Speaking content.
- **IELTS Simon** (ielts-simon.com) — model answers from an ex-examiner.
- **British Council "Take IELTS"** — official practice + tips.
- **IDP IELTS** — sample tests + free webinars.
- **BBC Learning English** — pronunciation, podcasts, news vocabulary.

14.3 YouTube channels

- IELTS Liz · E2 IELTS · IELTS Advantage · IELTS Daily · Adam's English Lessons (engVid)

14.4 Apps

- **IELTS Prep App** by British Council — free.
- **Magoosh IELTS** — paid, great if you're disciplined.
- **Quizlet** — flashcards (AWL deck is free).
- **Cambly / italki** — speaking partners with real teachers.

14.5 Podcasts for daily listening exposure

- All Ears English · IELTS Energy · 6-Minute English (BBC) · TED Talks Daily · The Documentary (BBC)

15. Test Day — Checklist & Mindset

15.1 Two days before

- ☐ No new material — only your templates and mistake log.
- ☐ Confirm test centre location and reporting time.
- ☐ Charge any required ID; print confirmation email.
- ☐ Buy 2 black-ink pens + 2 HB pencils + eraser + sharpener.
- ☐ Sleep 8 hours.

15.2 Morning of the test

- ☐ Eat a real breakfast (carbs + protein, not just coffee).
- ☐ Original passport (the same ID you registered with).
- ☐ Arrive 30–45 min early.
- ☐ Use the bathroom before each section if needed.

15.3 During the test — quick reminders

- **Listening:** read ahead in the gaps. If you miss one, jump forward — never look back.
- **Reading:** watch the clock — 17 / 20 / 22 min budget.
- **Writing:** 5-min plan, 14-min Task 1 write, 1-min check · 5-min plan, 33-min Task 2 write, 2-min check.
- **Speaking:** smile, make eye contact, treat it as a conversation, not an interrogation.

Mindset: the examiner is rooting for you. They want to give you Band 7. Your job is to make it easy by being clear, confident, and on-topic.

16. Common Mistakes & the Final-Week Strategy

16.1 The 10 most-common Band-6.5 mistakes

1. Studying without a diagnostic — wasting time on already-strong skills.
2. Reading IELTS tips instead of doing IELTS tests.
3. Memorising sample essays — examiners spot them and penalise.
4. Writing under or over the word limit.
5. Not addressing every part of the Task 2 question.
6. Skipping Writing Task 1 overview — automatic cap at Band 5.
7. Speaking too fast or in monotone (Indian-speaker habit).
8. Using "etc.", "&", or contractions in Writing.
9. Ignoring spelling and plurals in Listening.
10. Never getting work evaluated by a real examiner.

16.2 Final week — what to do (and not do)

Do	Don't
Light review of templates & mistake log	Learn new techniques 3 days out
One full mock 4 days before	Daily mocks until the last minute
Speaking practice with a partner	Cram vocabulary lists
Re-read your idea bank for Task 2	Memorise full essays
Sleep, exercise, eat well	Pull all-nighters
Visualise calm test day	Catastrophise about a single section

16.3 Closing note

Band 7 is reachable in 30–45 days if you do three things consistently:

1. Practise with **official Cambridge material**, timed, from Day 1.
2. Keep a **mistake log** and review it every Sunday.
3. Pay for at least **2 evaluations** each for Writing and Speaking — you cannot grade these yourself.

You are not learning English; you are learning the IELTS format. Most Indian working professionals have the language — they just need to learn the rules of this specific game.

— End of plan — All the best for your test and Master's journey!